

WOODPECKERS AND TOUCANS

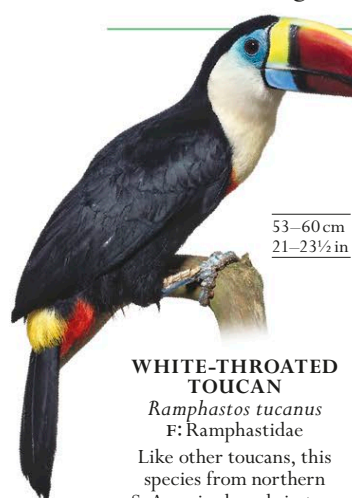
483

Mostly tree-dwelling cavity nesters, birds of this order, the Piciformes, have a common foot structure. More than half of the species are woodpeckers.

The woodpeckers are almost worldwide in distribution. These birds cling to trunks with zygodactyl feet typical of the order (two toes pointing forwards, two backwards) and, propped by their stiffened tail, drum through the wood with their strong bill. They extract prey with

a long barbed tongue. Other birds in the order are largely confined to the tropics. Honeyguides feed on the wax from raided bee nests. Jacamars hunt large insects while puffbirds are flycatchers. Barbets have a serrated bill for eating fruits; the tropical American barbets are cousins of the toucans. Honeyguides are brood parasites, laying eggs in the nests of other birds, including woodpeckers. Others in this group nest in tree-holes, or may dig out burrows in the ground or in termite mounds.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	PICIFORMES
FAMILIES	9
SPECIES	445



53–60 cm
21–23½ in

WHITE-THROATED TOUCAN

Ramphastos tucanus
F: Ramphastidae

Like other toucans, this species from northern S. America breeds in tree cavities, often making use of abandoned woodpecker nests.

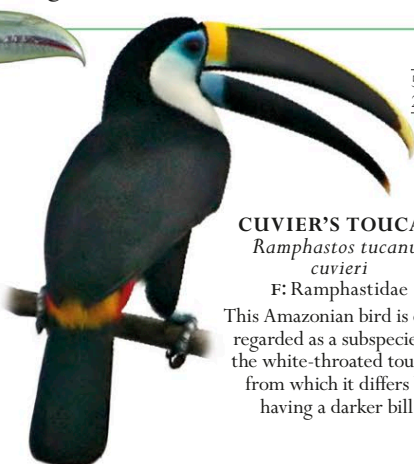


43 cm
17 in

RED-BREASTED TOUCAN

Ramphastos dicolorus
F: Ramphastidae

Among the smallest of the *Ramphastos* toucans, this species from eastern S. America is the only one with extensive red underparts.

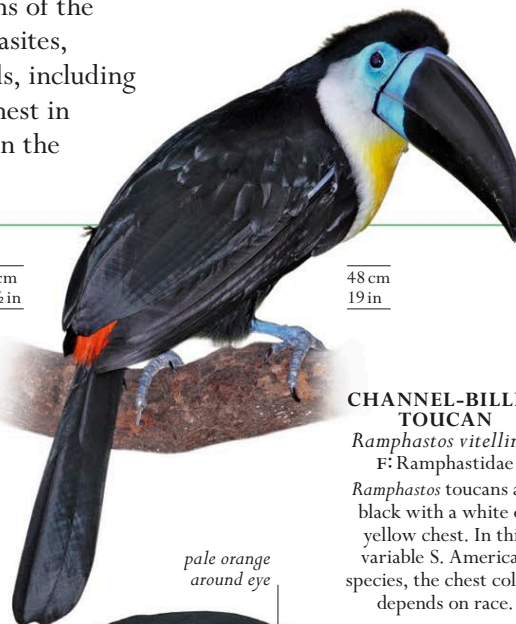


55–60 cm
22–23½ in

CUVIER'S TOUCAN

Ramphastos tucanus cuvieri
F: Ramphastidae

This Amazonian bird is often regarded as a subspecies of the white-throated toucan, from which it differs by having a darker bill.

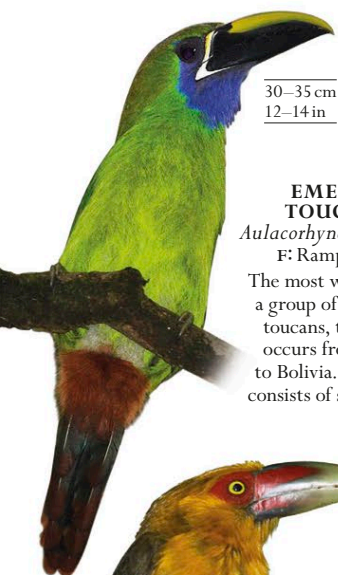


48 cm
19 in

CHANNEL-BILLED TOUCAN

Ramphastos vitellinus
F: Ramphastidae

Ramphastos toucans are black with a white or yellow chest. In this variable S. American species, the chest colour depends on race.

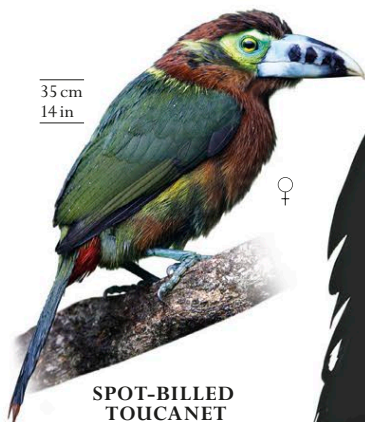


30–35 cm
12–14 in

EMERALD TOUCANET

Aulacorhynchus prasinus
F: Ramphastidae

The most widespread of a group of small green toucans, this species occurs from Mexico to Bolivia. The species consists of several races.



35 cm
14 in

SPOT-BILLED TOUCANET

Selenidera maculirostris
F: Ramphastidae

This S. Brazilian species is one of several dichromatic toucanets, which are the only toucans with different-coloured sexes. The females are marked with brown.

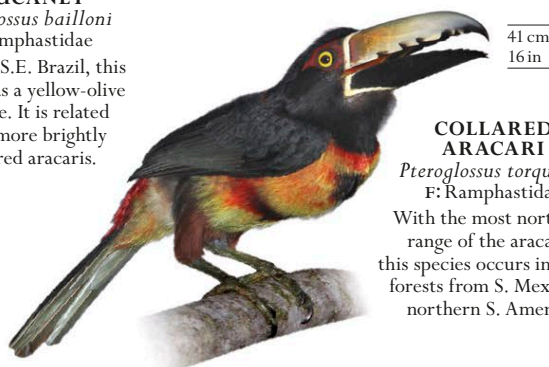


35–40 cm
14–16 in

SAFFRON TOUCANET

Pteroglossus bailloni
F: Ramphastidae

Found in S.E. Brazil, this toucan has a yellow-olive plumage. It is related to the more brightly coloured aracarís.



41 cm
16 in

COLLARED ARACARI

Pteroglossus torquatus
F: Ramphastidae

With the most northerly range of the aracarís, this species occurs in humid forests from S. Mexico to northern S. America.



55–65 cm
22–26 in

TOCO TOUCAN

Ramphastos toco
F: Ramphastidae

This bird from northern S. America is the largest of the toucans. Unlike other forest species, it also inhabits more open woodland habitats.



37 cm
14½ in

CHESTNUT-EARED ARACARI

Pteroglossus castanotis
F: Ramphastidae

Aracarís are long-tailed, gregarious toucans. Most have a red rump and prominent bands on the belly. This species is from northwestern S. America.